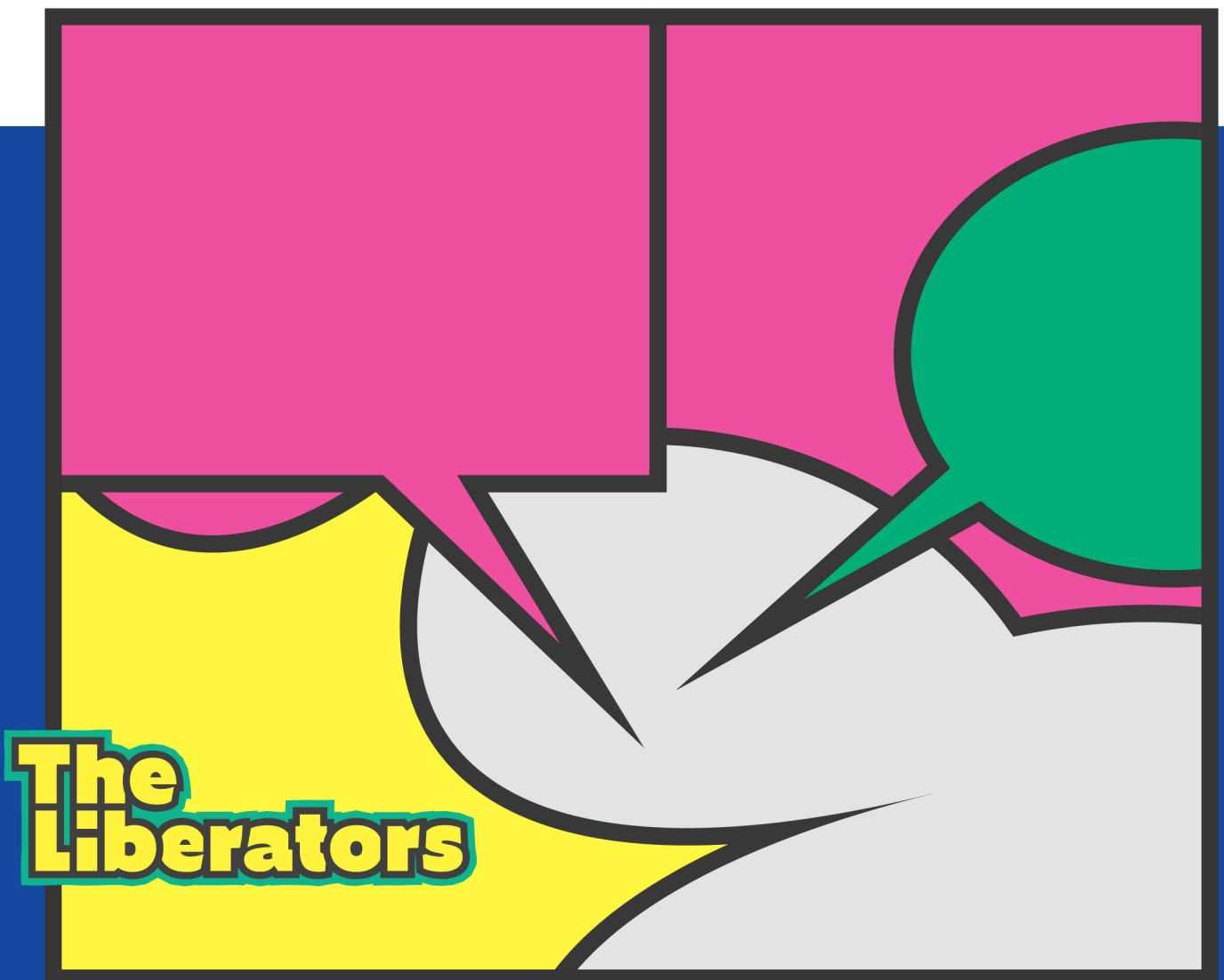


Use Proven Success Factors From The Past, To Improve Your Team In The Present

A do-it-yourself workshop that uses Appreciative Interviews to share success stories from the past, Ecocycle Planning to create transparency about the present, and 15% Solutions to identify improvements for the nearby future



The Purpose Of This Workshop

Hey there,

We created [Columinity](#) to support Scrum and other Agile teams in their continuous improvement loop. The first step in that loop is to create transparency around where you are right now, and then to work together as a team to identify improvements and make adaptations.

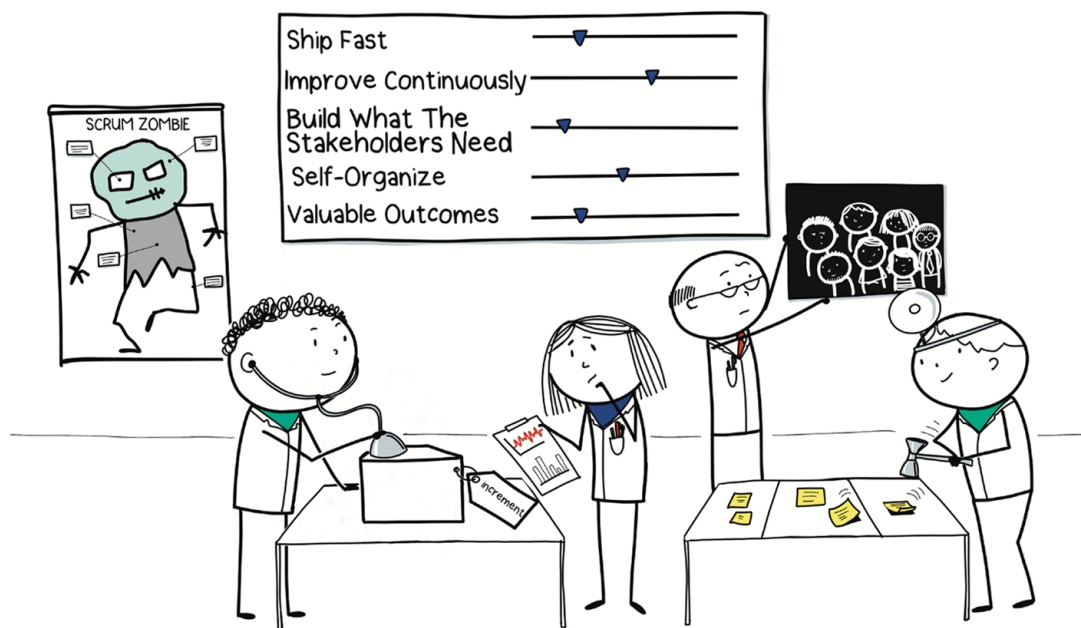
This do-it-yourself workshop is built on the factors from the survey. It uses Appreciative Interviews to share success stories from the past, Ecocycle Planning to create transparency about the present, and 15% Solutions to identify improvements for the nearby future.

It can be used independently from the tool. As such, it's a powerful conversation starter. Eventually, our recommendation is to use the (free) survey to bring real data into the conversation and to identify improvements.

Give it a try, and let us know the results!

Barry & Christiaan

The Liberators



Created by Theo Schukken for the Zombie Scrum Survival Guide
by Christiaan Verwijs, Johannes Scharlau & Barry Overeem
zombiescrum.org

Flow



Step 1: Hi! Hi! Hi!



5 min

Step 2: Share Success Stories With Appreciative Interviews



35 min

Step 3: Explore The Foundations Of Effective Scrum Teams



20 min

Step 4: Use Ecocycle Planning To Make The Current State Of Scrum Transparent



15 min

Step 5: Sharing Patterns And Findings



25 min

Step 6: Identify Improvements



20 min

Step 7: Closing

5 min

Total duration

125 min

Difficulty / Effort



Required Skill



Ecocycle Planning can look overwhelming, but just give it a try and let the structure do the heavy lifting.

Impact On Survival



Appreciative Interviews build trust within the group. Trust that is necessary to cope with the transparency Ecocycle Planning creates. Full transparency results in meaningful improvements.

How To Prepare

Group Size

This workshop is feasible from 8 participants and onward and takes about 120 minutes. You can quickly scale this workshop up to many Scrum teams as well.

Intended Audience

We designed this workshop for one Scrum team, but our recommendation is to also invite your supporters (managers, leaders, coaches), stakeholders, and other Scrum teams. Try it together, and see what becomes possible. This workshop is also suitable to run during public meetups. It's interesting to explore the differences between the various organizations that might be joining the meetup.

Virtual Delivery

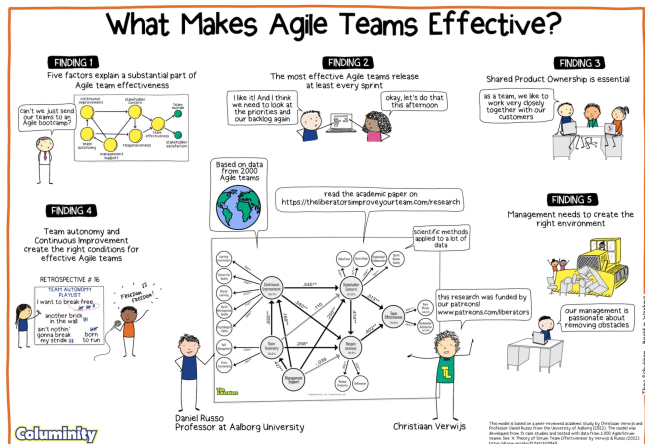
Liberating Structures work well virtually. Here too, they allow you to unleash and involve everyone. What is exceptionally important, however, is that you have the right tools. Because Liberating Structures are fundamentally about breaking down large-group interactions into smaller groups, you need tools that allow you to create subchannels or breakout rooms easily. [Zoom](#) is ideal for this, but similar features are available in tools like [Teams](#) and [GotoMeeting](#). We also recommend a virtual whiteboard where you can collect shared insights, like [Mural](#), [Miro](#), or [Google Slides](#). Even [Slack](#) can work.

Preparation

- A1 Poster – "[What makes Scrum teams effective?](#)"
- A1 Poster – "[Factors that determine Scrum team effectiveness](#)"
- For each participant, a printed copy (A4 format) of the poster "[Factors that determine Scrum team effectiveness](#)"
- For each participant, a printed copy (A4 format) of [Ecocycle Planning](#)
- A [15% Solution card deck](#) to capture the improvements

Resources

- Whitepaper: [Scrum: A Framework to Reduce Risk And Deliver Value Sooner](#)
- Blog post: [In-Depth: What Makes Scrum Teams Effective?](#)
- Academic paper: [A Theory Of Scrum Team Effectiveness](#)
- Tool: [Scrum Team Survey](#)
- Book: [Zombie Scrum Survival Guide](#)
- Product Kit: [Unleash Scrum In Your Organization](#)



Product Kit: Unleash Scrum In Your Organization

Scrum impacts the entire organization. To unlock your Scrum team's superpowers, improvements are necessary within and especially around teams. We created this kit to help see the bigger picture. It's filled with materials to diagnose Scrum in your organization and unleashes its potential with Scrum.

Although [the product](#) kit isn't necessary material for this workshop, it can help to dig deeper into the results. The product kit contains the following (physical and/or virtual) materials:

- The exercise **"Panarchy"** to diagnose Scrum in your organization. You help Scrum teams, stakeholders, and supporters understand how their system works and find leverage points for improvement.
- The exercise **"What I Need From You"**. It helps Scrum teams to clearly express their needs and for others to clearly respond to those requests. The exercise includes a 50-sheet block of tearable 'help request cards'.
- A card deck with **102 Quick Tips** to improve your Scrum team. We categorized them into the factors you also find in the Scrum Team Survey.
- **5 Impediment cards**. Impediments are problems the team can't resolve themselves. Use these 5 impediment cards to make visible where you're stuck and need support from others to improve the situation.
- A 50-sheet block of tearable **15% Solution-cards**. Ready to be filled out by members of your team.
- Poster: **"What makes Scrum teams effective?"**. This poster (A1 format) offers a nice, visual overview of the core findings from our scientific investigation into what makes Scrum teams effective.
- Poster: **"Factors that determine Scrum team effectiveness"**. This poster (A1 format) offers an overview of all the 20+ factors that determine a Scrum team's effectiveness.
- A **facilitation guide**. You receive a 16-page PDF that describes how to use the included exercises.

[You can find more information about the product kit here](#)





Step 1: Hi! Hi! Hi!

Start at the scheduled time. People who drop in later can jump in then. We always start our gatherings by simply saying "Hi!", followed by our name. We then explain the purpose and start with the first structure. Superfast!



Step 2: Share Success Stories With Appreciative Interviews

We've found that it works best if you build personal connections from what people are proud of, or have warm memories about. The Liberating Structure [Appreciative Interviews](#) is a great way to do this.

Invitation

In pairs, share a story of a time when you worked with a successful Agile or Scrum team. What happened? What did the team do or didn't do? What made the success possible?

Steps

1. **2 min** Explain the sequence of steps upfront so that people know they will be sharing a story, listening to another story, and then re-telling the story they listened to.
2. **2 min** Give participants a few minutes to silently bring back into memory a success story from their past, or at least the start of it.
3. **10 min** Invite pairs into their own breakouts. In turn (5 min each), people interview each other about the success story of the other while paying attention to what made the success possible. The interviewer only asks questions (no advice, suggestions, etc.).
4. **10 min** Invite pairs to join another pair in new breakouts. Everyone retells the story of the person they interviewed. The other three participants listen for patterns in conditions/assets that supported the success. Invite groups to capture the most salient factors in your virtual whiteboard.
5. **10 min** When everyone is back in the main channel, collect insights from the group. Ask people to share some examples of what created the insights for them. The purpose here is not to collect everything, but mostly to spread ideas around. So don't let this go on and on.

Our findings

- We often encourage people to channel a journalist that they admire or frequently read articles from in the newspaper. Frequently, this makes people ask deeper questions.

Resources

- Blogpost: [Discovering and Building on the Root Causes of Success with Appreciative Interviews](#)
- The original article on [Appreciative Interviews](#) on the website of Liberating Structures





Step 3: Explore The Foundations Of Effective Scrum Teams

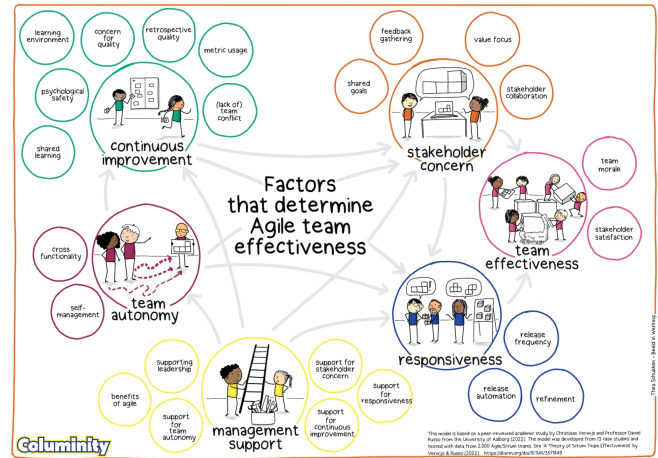
Now that everyone has loosened up, made some fresh connections, and shared personal success stories, it's time to have the group explore the Scrum team effectiveness model. The Liberating Structure [1-2-4-ALL](#) is a great way to do this together, interactively.

Steps

- 1 min** Prepare by putting the posters on the wall or in a digital workspace. Make sure that everyone can clearly see and read the posters. Bring more copies if necessary.
- 4 min** Invite everyone to silently review the posters.
- 1 min** Ask: "In silence and individually, identify the two things from the posters that seem most meaningful or impactful to you". These could be factors they already identified during Appreciative Interviews or totally new ones.
- 2 min** Invite people to pair up with one other person and share their takeaways. Set up breakout rooms if you do this virtually. Ask: "In your pair, share your biggest insights and build on them together".
- 4 min** Invite the pairs to pair up with another pair to form groups of four as much as possible. Ask: "In your small groups, share your biggest insights and build on them together".
- 10 min** With the whole group, collect the most critical insights and questions. Try to answer the questions by putting your insights together.

Resources

- Blog post: [In-Depth: What Makes Scrum Teams Effective?](#)
- Academic paper: [A Theory Of Scrum Team Effectiveness](#)
- Poster: ["What makes Scrum teams effective?"](#)
- Poster: ["Factors that determine Scrum team effectiveness"](#)
- 1-2-4-ALL: the [original article](#) from the Liberating Structures website
- Blog post: [Engage Everyone Simultaneously in Generating Questions, Ideas, and Suggestions with 1-2-4-ALL](#)



Ecocycle Planning: A Metaphor From Nature

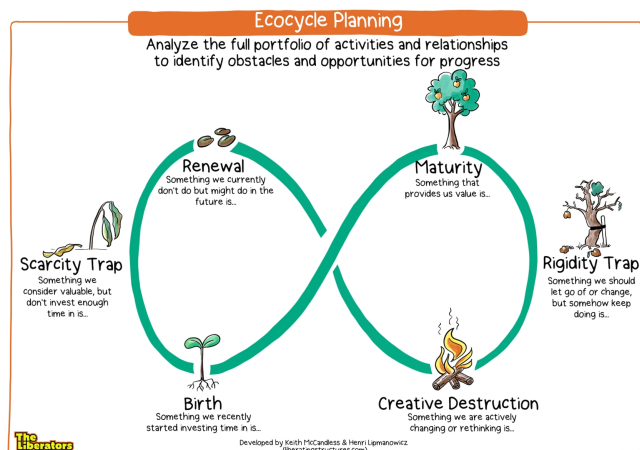
Ecocycle Planning is part of the repertoire of Liberating Structures. Its purpose is to analyze the full portfolio of activities and identify obstacles and opportunities for progress in a markedly non-linear way. That makes it an excellent way to periodically reflect on your work together and to decide what to focus on next. It is based on the life cycle in nature.

The activities of your Scrum team can be plotted on an Ecocycle as follows:

- **Renewal** represents all the activities that you think would be useful to you as a team, but that you are not doing at the moment.
- **Birth** represents the activities that you have just started doing as a team, or that you've been investing in. Although they are not fully valuable yet, and probably take effort and discipline to do, they will become increasingly valuable as you keep doing them.
- **Maturity** represents the activities that are comfortable and valuable to you as a team. It doesn't take much effort or discipline to do them. It's become part of your rhythm as a Scrum Team.
- **Creative Destruction** represents the activities that have either lost their value to you as a team or need to be reinvented in order to become useful again. Perhaps by doing it in a different way or from a different perspective. Or you want to stop doing them altogether.

All activities flow through the Ecocycle. But they can also get stuck. Activities that you know are important but are never invested in, get stuck in the Poverty/Scarcity Trap. Activities that you keep doing, but aren't really adding any value any longer, are in the Rigidity Trap. By plotting all your activities across the Ecocycle, you can identify patterns that tell you something about where you are as a team. Look for the following patterns in particular:

- A healthy Ecocycle is balanced. There is innovation taking place, as evidenced by activities on the left of the model, and there are activities that are mature, as evidenced by items on the right. Furthermore, teams are continuously reinventing how to do things and become better, as represented in what is in Creative Destruction.
- Activities that are in the Rigidity Trap and Creative Destruction are prime candidates for reinvention or even removal. Start there before adding new activities, as this creates space for something new.





Step 4: Use Ecocycle Planning To Make The Current State Of Scrum Transparent

In the previous steps, the group shared stories about successful teams they've been part of and identified the success factors that stood out. Afterward, you explained the model of Scrum team effectiveness with the primary and subfactors. In this step, you help the participants reflect on how the factors connect to their own team. Ecocycle Planning is perfectly suited for this. It creates transparency about the state of Scrum at this moment. From there, you can start the inspection and adaptation.

Steps

- **2 min** Distribute A4-sized illustrations "Factors that determine Scrum team effectiveness" and "Ecocycle Planning". At this point, everyone is familiar with the illustration containing all the factors. Ecocycle Planning is most likely not known to the group. If this is the case: totally fine, don't explain Ecocycle Planning yet.
- **10 min** One by one, present six prompts for everyone to complete on their Ecocycle Planning illustration. After each prompt, pause to give them time to write down their answer in the specified quadrant, with their current team in mind.

Top left (Gestation): "A factor that my team is unaware of or hasn't started using is..."

Bottom left (Birth): "A factor my team recently started using or investing time in is..."

Top right (Maturity): "A factor that provides lots of value for my team is..."

Bottom-right (Creative Destruction): "A factor we are currently rethinking, changing, or creatively destructing is..."

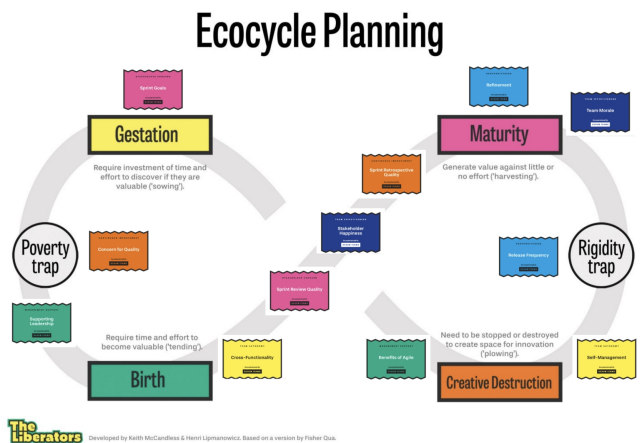
Middle left (Poverty Trap): "A factor, we consider valuable, talk about a lot, but somehow don't invest enough time in is..."

Middle right (Rigidity Trap): "A factor, we keep doing, despite we know that the current way of using it doesn't generate much value anymore is..."

- **3 min** Once you've offered all the prompts, give the participants some time to individually reflect on the Ecocycle that emerged. Maybe they want to move some factors around or they've got questions that need to be clarified.

Our findings

- It's probably easiest for the participants to plot the subfactors on the Ecocycle because these are more specific compared to the primary factors.
- After each statement, invite the groups to have a quick conversation about what factor they've chosen. This can help people understand Ecocycle Planning better, and brings back a bit of energy. This step would replace the full Impromptu Networking in step 5. Still do step 5, but only make it one round. Or as a shout-out.





Step 5: Sharing Patterns And Findings

In the previous step, you created transparency around the current state of Scrum in your team. Based on how you answered the prompts/sentences, you plotted some of the factors that determine a Scrum team's effectiveness on the Ecocycle. The purpose of this step is to make sense of what this means for your team.

Steps

1. **4 min** Invite people to reflect on the individual Ecocycles you created in the previous step. Ask "What does the placement of the factors say about the state of Scrum in your/our team? Where do you see connections between the various factors?". In the meantime, prepare breakouts for three rounds of different pairs.
2. **15 min** Invite people into pairs and into their breakouts. Ask them to share the most salient patterns they notice (4 minutes). Repeat twice more in different pairs (8 minutes).
3. **10 min** When everyone is back in the main channel, ask people to share the most salient patterns with the whole group. You can help draw out patterns by noticing where most cards of one color appear, whether or not the Ecocycle is balanced and which items appear in the traps.

Our Findings

- We purposefully use pairs, and not larger groups, to create safety for everyone to share their insights. Even in small groups, loud voices can drown out silent voices. By quickly rotating pairs, great insights and observations will spread through the group. If you really must do it with a larger group, use a [Conversation Cafe](#).
- Use "Creative Destruction" as the area where activities go that need to be creatively re-invented to be valuable again. An Ecocycle Planning with nothing in this area may be an indicator that double-loop learning – where existing structures are challenged – is limited in your team.



Step 6: Identify Improvements

In the previous steps, you created transparency together around the state of Scrum for your team. Then, you identified the impact together. In this final step, you help the team identify improvements.

Steps

1. **5 min** First individually and in silence, ask people to consider the following question for a few minutes: "Which factors do we need to creatively reinvent in order to move the way we use Scrum forward?". In the meantime, prepare breakouts for pairs and – for the step after that – breakouts with two pairs each.
2. **15 min** Invite people into pairs and into their breakouts to share their ideas and build on them **5 min**. Then, invite the pairs into new breakouts with another pair to share their ideas and build on them **10 min**.
3. **5 min** When everyone is back in the main channel, ask every group to share two or three of their most promising ideas. Capture these potential improvements on 15% Solutions cards to make them tangible.
4. If you have the time and when the improvement ideas remain fairly abstract, you can use a Liberating Structure like ["Shift & Share"](#) to develop them further.

Our Findings

- You can also use [25/10 Crowd Sourcing](#) to quickly generate improvement ideas. David Heath created this [free virtual app](#) to do this online.
- When you are facing tough impediments, you can use Liberating Structures like [Discovery & Action Dialogue](#) and [Wise Crowds](#) to dig deeper.

Step 7: Closing

With this workshop, you used Appreciative Interviews to share success stories from the past, Ecocycle Planning to create transparency about the present, and 15% Solutions to identify improvements for the nearby future.

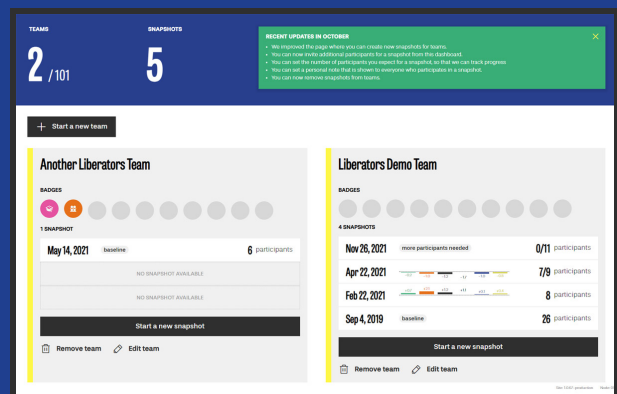
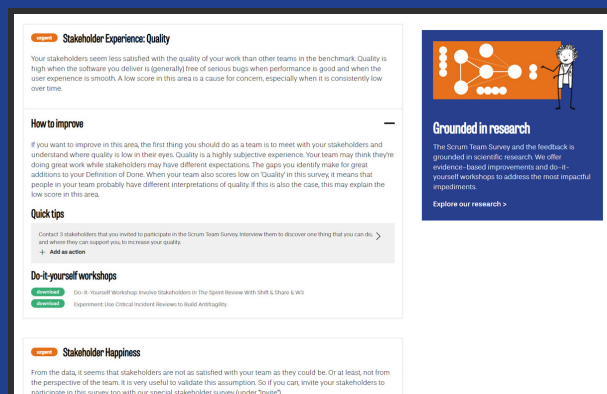
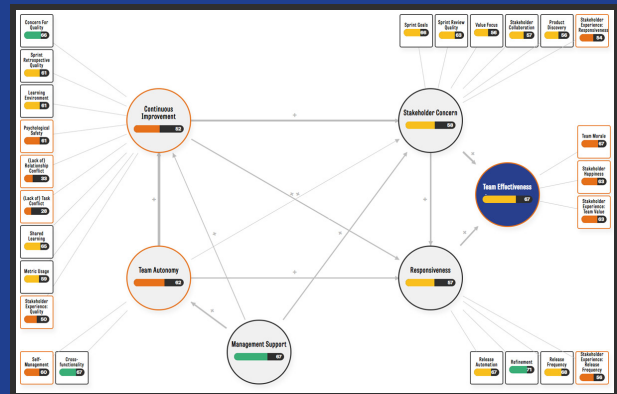
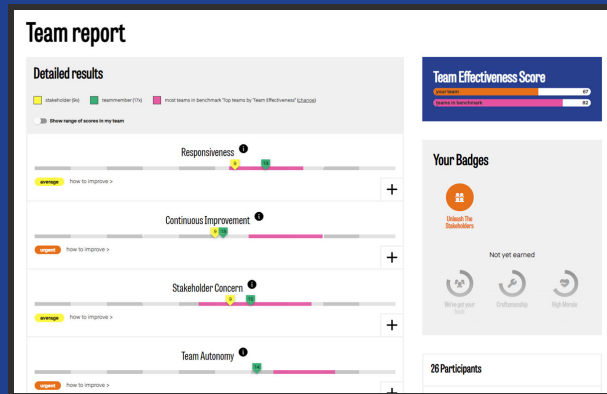
If you've got any questions, comments, or ideas: always feel free to reach out and share them with us.

Let's learn and grow, together!



Make Your Scrum Team More Effective

Want to make your Scrum team more effective? We created the Scrum Team Survey to help. Invite members and stakeholders to a detailed questionnaire and diagnose the results together. You receive tons of actionable feedback based on your results, including dozens of quick tips and useful do-it-yourself workshops. You can use the Scrum Team Survey for free with your team. No account or e-mail address is required. You can also subscribe for more advanced features.



	Essential	Liberator
Invite team members & stakeholders	unlimited	unlimited
Quick Tips for your team per topic	3	unlimited
Recommendations to your team	5	unlimited
Compare your team against different benchmarks		✓
Maintain one or many teams from a single dashboard		✓
Receive our personal guidance on how to get started		✓
See where your team improves over time with Insights		✓
Unlimited data retention		✓
Pricing per team per month	€ 0	€ 15

<https://scrumteamsurvey.org>

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Unleashing Teams All Over The World

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